



Beast mode: Dominic Thiem was the last man with a one-handed backhand to win a Major, in 2020. Unlike many of his contemporaries, his one-hander was lethal. For him, it was not a defensive tool, but rather a weapon he used to assert dominance against anyone across the net.

turn of the next decade, the narrative had flipped. In the 2010 year-end rankings, players employing the shot had become a minority, with just two in the top 10. Then, in the weekly rankings released on February 19, 2024, there were none for the first time in history — a truly watershed moment.

Cut to today, its presence in the top 100 has dwindled to a handful — five men and four women. Among them, Italy's Lorenzo Musetti is the highest-ranked one, at No. 20, with a career-high ranking of fifth. The Italian was knocked out in the second round of the 2026 US Open and will need a strong finish to the season to return to the year-end top 10.

"Tennis used to be played with so many different variations of style, and that variation has narrowed to one particular style these days, where everyone is playing the same. It's such a traditional, classic shot that it's a shame to lose it like that," lamented Tsitsipas.

The decline is also reflected in the Grand Slams. Dominic Thiem was the last man with a one-handed backhand to win a Major, in 2020. In the women's game, you have to go even further back, to Francesca Schiavone in 2010. Thiem's achievement particularly assumes importance because unlike many of his contemporaries, his one-hander was lethal. For him, it was not a defensive tool, but rather a weapon he used to assert dominance against anyone across the net.

Meeting the ball early, Thiem says, was the key ingredient behind his powerful backhand. "Earlier in my career I played my backhand from quite far behind the baseline. Over the years I worked a lot on taking the ball earlier and being more aggressive with it. My slice was pretty useful as well because having different options was very important, especially against players who were constantly putting pressure on my backhand," Thiem told *Sportstar*.

